# Vibhuti Mehta

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**Placement Director:** Kelly Bishop (Kelly.Bishop@asu.edu)

**Placement Coordinator:** Laura Talts (LTalts@asu.edu)

## EDUCATION

**Arizona State University** 2021-2027
Ph.D. in Economics

**University of Wisconsin-Madison** 2019-2021
M.S. in Economics

**Birla Institute of Technology & Science (BITS), Pilani** 2012-2016
B.Sc. in Economics

## RESEARCH FIELDS

Labor Economics, Health Economics, Education Economics

## REFERENCES

**Esteban Aucejo (Chair)**
Professor
Department of Economics
Arizona State University
esteban.aucejo@asu.edu

**Alvin Murphy**
Associate Professor
Department of Economics
Arizona State University
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**Samuel Young**
Assistant Professor
Department of Economics
Arizona State University
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## WORKING PAPERS

**"Licensing Barriers to Interstate Mobility: Evidence from Travel Nurses"** *(Job Market Paper)*

Interstate licensing barriers can limit healthcare workers' responses to surges in demand in the US, yet little is known about their effects on labor market adjustment. Focusing on travel nursing during the COVID-19 pandemic, this paper quantifies these effects and provides the first estimate of workers' willingness to accept (WTA) interstate licensing barriers. Using novel application data, I develop and estimate a structural model of the travel nurse labor market. The model combines discrete-choice application decisions with county-level monopsonistic wage setting under decreasing returns to scale. Application choices reflect licensing barriers, distance, and destination characteristics, including wages and COVID-19 cases. Exploiting variation from individual nurse license and emergency licensing waivers adopted during COVID-19, the results show that licensing barriers substantially deter applications. Nurses' WTA is a 30% wage premium to apply where they lack a license, more than double the increase needed to apply twice as far from home. Emergency waivers increased applications only with a lag. Counterfactual estimates show that recognizing out-of-state licenses before the pandemic would have avoided this delay, increasing applications during the initial COVID-19 shock with modest wage effects. The findings favor permanent agreements over temporary emergency measures.

**"The Mortality Effects of Interstate Licensing Barriers to Mobility: Evidence from Nurse Licensure Compact"**

Public health emergencies create urgent demand for nurses, but state licensing requirements can impede their movement across state lines. This paper examines whether these barriers raised mortality during the COVID-19 pandemic. I exploit cross-state variation in membership in the Nurse Licensure Compact (NLC), which lets nurses practice across member states with a single license, together with the emergency waivers that temporarily

suspended licensing requirements from March 2020. Using county-level mortality data from the CDC, I compare neighboring counties across NLC and non-NLC state borders in a boundary discontinuity design. In the first half of 2020, deaths per capita in non-NLC counties rose by 6% relative to their NLC neighbors, equivalent to about 14 additional deaths per 100,000 residents. The gap closed in the second half of 2020. These findings are consistent with a delayed response to emergency waivers and suggest that lags in nurse reallocation can have substantial mortality consequences during public health emergencies.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

**"Universal Vouchers and the Composition of Public School Exits: Evidence from Arizona"** *(with Esteban Aucejo and Alex Toy)*

In 2022, Arizona became the first state to make its Empowerment Scholarship Account (ESA) program available to every K–12 student. Using administrative records on all Arizona public school students from 2016 to 2023, we examine who used an ESA during the first year of universal eligibility and whether the expansion changed who left the public school system. Students receiving special education services were about 1.7 percentage points more likely to use an ESA - more than twice the overall take-up rate of 1.5%. Among racial and ethnic groups, White students had the highest take-up. To separate changes in selection from preexisting patterns, we compare students leaving public schools before COVID-19, during the pandemic, and after the expansion. Students receiving special education services stand out: they were already more likely to leave, and this gap doubled after the expansion.

**"The Impact of School Quality Grades on Student Transfers and Universal Voucher Uptake"** *(with Esteban Aucejo and Alex Toy)*

Arizona assigns every public school an A-F grade and, since 2022, has made public funding available to all families seeking alternatives outside the public school system. We examine how these grades affect students' decisions to leave public schools and whether the universal expansion of the Empowerment Scholarship Account (ESA) program changed this response. Using administrative data on all Arizona public school students from 2016 to 2023, we employ a regression discontinuity design comparing schools just above and below the letter-grade cutoffs. Before COVID-19, schools narrowly receiving a higher grade had an exit rate 0.5 percentage points lower than those narrowly receiving a lower grade, relative to an average of 8.3%. Preliminary results suggest that this gap disappeared during the pandemic and remained absent after the ESA expansion.

## ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS

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| ASU PhD Reunion Conference | 2026 |
| Annual Health Econometrics Workshop | 2026 |
| Policy Research Workshop, Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) | 2026 |
| Western Economic Association International (WEAI) - Graduate Student Workshop | 2026 |
| American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon) | 2025, 2026 |
| Western Economic Association International (WEAI) | 2024 |
| Arizona State University - General Economics Workshop | 2024, 2025, 2026 |

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

**Arizona State University**

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|---|---|
| Research Assistant for Esteban Aucejo | 2024-Present |
| Research Assistant for Ellen P. Green | Summer 2024 |
| Research Assistant for Paula Calvo | Summer 2023 |

**University of Wisconsin-Madison**

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| Research Assistant for Rikhil R. Bhavnani | 2020 |

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

**Arizona State University, Instructor**
Applied Regression and Data Analytics — Spring 2026

**Arizona State University, Teaching Assistant (selected)**
Gender and Family Economics — Spring 2023, 2025
Applied Regression and Data Analytics — Fall 2023, 2024
International Trade Theory — Spring 2024

## EMPLOYMENT

**Credit Suisse Business Analytics Limited, India** — 2016-2019
Economic Research Analyst

## ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Languages: English (Fluent), Hindi (Native)

Programming: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, Qualtrics, LaTeX